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Worst Mistake Made by Early Civilizations

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HIS-111: World Civilization

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November 30, 2024

What was the single worst mistake made by early civilizations (prior to 1500)?

There are countless mistakes made by early civilizations that have subsequently shifted the modern world, whether it be minuscule or major. As these early civilizations navigate life and experience war, and tragedies, further implementing their beliefs and ethics into society, they pave the path for future generations, whether that be in a harmful or beneficial manner. Power comes from many sources—money, status, and authority—but it is religion that sustains it, making it the worst mistake made by early civilizations. Agriculture laid the grounds for negative societal structures, and religion solidified these systems, forming the basis of inequality that continues to affect society today.

Before the neolithic revolution and the birth of agriculture occurred, hunter-gatherers were egalitarian groups that had no social hierarchy of the sort; they would eat what they hunted, and everyone played a major role, regardless of gender. However, this shifted as civilizations began settling and relying on crops as their food source, one of these civilizations was the Mesopotamians. Agriculture impacted society in many ways and the modern age is still recovering from the consequences of it. It caused a variety of issues that affected the past and seeped into contemporary times. Despite the health concerns this implemented, there are deeper issues that led to ones that the modern world still suffers from. Mesopotamians began the practice of gender inequality, as women's rights were minimized. While they were still able to own land and engage in trade like men, they were seen and treated like property. This is reflected in the code of Hammurabi, as women who did not 'behave' were given grave repercussions, such as drowning, while men did not receive the same treatment. This stemmed from the beginning of the social hierarchy that is seen in Egypt as well. Egyptian women had more rights than Mesopotamian women and were the closest to gender equality in early civilizations. In addition to gender inequality, hierarchy is also responsible for division in society by early civilizations such as Mesopotamia and Egypt. Society was divided into an upper class which consisted of pharaohs and kings, a middle class which consisted of nobles and scribes, and the lower class consisting of farmers and slaves.

Inequality further spread to the Indus River Valley civilization, in which the caste system was created a harsher system with no inflexibility. The short-term effect reinforced segregation and tied social roles to religion, such as Brahmanism, within the caste system. While Greece did not copy the caste system that the Indus River Valley civilization had, they still carried on the inequality hierarchy brought. In the epic *Antigone*, written by Sophocles, it was evident that women were seen as inferior and weaker than men. This forced women to be excluded from democracy while it was being cemented into Athens, as they were unable to vote or own land. Additionally, *Works and Days* displays glimpses of the harsh lifestyle of farmers in Athens, despite being the main source of food and income for the farmers and the Athenians during their transition from aristocracy to democracy. Sparta had similar roles for women, with little to no government control that they held. One of the most significant classes, aside from the upper class, that agriculture remains exclusively responsible for is slavery. Slaves supported significant architectural projects, such as the pyramids for the Egyptians and ziggurats for Mesopotamians that benefited the civilizations short term, but normalized labor exploitation tied to race and class in the long term. Particularly in Sparta, as the city-state was run by Helots and supported by them, it even outnumbered Spartans 25:1. The main theme that agriculture influenced was division, which ultimately led to unequal gender roles and societal inequality. These themes, however, are the contributing factors to our present.

Jared Diamond suggests that “Farming helped bring another curse upon humanity: deep class divisions” (Diamond, 1987). Many of the issues mentioned above are accountable for the long-term effects experienced today. Hierarchy leads to patriarchy, in which men dominate every aspect of society, including women. An additional example is women being denied medical treatment. Poulomi Chakrabarti, in her article “Status and Development: How Social Hierarchy Undermines Well-Being”, notes that “women’s pain is taken less seriously by the medical community that disproportionately affects women” (Chakrabarti, 2022). In the short term, this limits women’s roles in leadership positions and overall societal impact. This is seen in our previous history of presidents in the United States, as a woman has never been president when running against their male opponents. In the long term, patriarchy supports

inequality in many fields, including medicine, law, and engineering. Moreover, women in such fields are paid significantly less than men, regardless of receiving the same certification, enforcing a wage gap that has only widened. In other countries, such as Afghanistan, the oppression of women is much harsher due to patriarchy and the development of hierarchy. Women are denied education, work, and rights under Taliban rule, as well as being banned from showing their faces or skin, making Afghan women endure an amplified version of gender inequality that agriculture implemented.

Furthermore, the influence of the upper class in the legal system displays acts of corruption and injustice. Public figures and higher-class individuals are excluded from hefty crimes due to financial stability or significance. This becomes evident as the recently elected president is a convicted felon, despite the qualification's prohibition. The corruption of the legal system due to social class goes hand in hand with patriarchy, as it is typically women who withstand harsher punishments. Another example of the long-term effects of agriculture is the modern-day caste system in India. Despite it being less prevalent, India's society still executes caste systems that individuals are born into and unable to escape. This gives them less access to work opportunities and to excel overall in their lives due to their caste defining their character. However, this is not just happening to those within caste systems, minorities overall do not receive proper treatment due to race. "Blacks in the United States and Dalits in India are more likely to be employed in low-paying and low-status occupations" (Chakrabarti, 2022). Slavery made room for racism, discrimination, and labor exploitation among minorities. These affect people of color in receiving the same opportunities, benefits, and respect as white individuals obtain with ease, and this is primarily due to the invention of agriculture. Agriculture created a hierarchy that ultimately put a heavy burden on society and will forever be intertwined in the way individuals live, with women and minorities bearing the heaviest burden. This lays the foundation of a momentous mistake: religion.

While agriculture created the material basis for hierarchy, religion allowed that hierarchy to become unquestionable; people could not challenge their position in society. Similarly to agriculture, religion began in Mesopotamia. Their government was a theocracy, in which political authority was in the hands of religious leaders, who were divinely guided by gods. The code of Hammurabi was created in the

context of theocracy to protect society, mainly consisting of harsh punishments that were determined by the gods. The short-term effect of this assisted in maintaining social order and refrained misconduct. However, the long-term effect allowed for social class discrimination among women, but it also gave a temporary answer for the tragedies the Mesopotamians endured. The consistent invasions and disasters they endured made them adopt a pessimistic view of life. Disease, invasions, and natural disasters were seen as direct punishments from their gods. This led to a negative depiction of Mesopotamian gods, as seen in an excerpt of the Mesopotamian wisdom literature in which a severely ill man does everything to please the gods, but his condition worsens. "My God has not come to the rescue nor taken me by the hand; My goddess has not shown pity on me nor gone by my side" (Perry et al., 2006). Egypt followed the same form of theocratic government the Mesopotamians had applied, with additional divine right pharaohs that tied religion directly to power structures, with religion refrained from being questioned, as pharaohs were not just rulers, but gods too. To go against the pharaoh means going against the gods, ultimately leading to blasphemy. In the short term, this minimized rebellions, but the prolonged effect provided irrational answers to circumstances and a lack of questioning of government and societal norms.

Greece similarly had religion heavily tied into their government, despite becoming a democracy. Leaders would use the Oracle at Delphi for further guidance on a variety of conflicts, such as war. For instance, during the Persian wars, Themistocles asked the Oracle at Delphi for the best course of action to lead Greeks during war, putting the fate of the military behind a communicator of the divine who is not proven to be connected to gods by any means. Additionally, when philosophers, such as Socrates, would be the one to question democracy and its validity to society; he was executed for corruption of youth and blasphemy. Socrates believed that democracy merely elevated power to the demagogues and challenged religious norms that were embedded into Athenian democracy. Philosophers like Socrates were disliked by society for providing answers outside of the gods, such as Thales discovering natural phenomena and Hippocrates applying it to medicine, attempting to diminish the early Mesopotamian belief that disease and natural disasters were caused by gods, angered the public. despite Athens' strong belief in the ability

to reason and humanism, philosophy greatly supports the encouragement of rational and logical thinking to please the Olympian gods.

Religion is a large factor of our lives, influencing morals, actions, war, and laws. As best defined by Sabah Mofidi in his research paper “The Negative Impact of Religion on Politics: An Analysis of Dysfunctions”, “Religion is considered as a series of beliefs, and one of the social structures in society with many social functions” (Mofidi, 2023). It’s been argued whether religion was founded or invented and regardless of which is claimed to be true, it is evident upon previous civilizations that religion has had a major negative impact on society and the way it has constructed the 21st century. A case in point is Separation of church and state enacted in the first amendment, in which laws are not to be created with the influence of religion, should not interfere with the government, and should not be forced upon a nation. This, however, is not followed to its full extent in the United States. Many cases have challenged this, such as *Roe v. Wade*, an ongoing case in which abortion is argued to be unconstitutional. Laws and cases are handled upon the Supreme Court of Justice, whose members use their personal stances and religion to interfere with the constitution to justify their rulings derived from personal religious beliefs. This is similar to how the Ecclesia in Athens operated, doing what they assume is best for their personal interest, such as the Peloponnesian war, agreeing to invade Syracuse as it benefited them financially and Socrates challenging religion.

The embodiment of religion in politics is more common in other theocratic Muslim countries, such as Saudi Arabia and Iran, using Islamic laws to discriminate towards groups of people. Mofidi states that “The Muslim rulers of the modern world’s Islamic countries have been able to control change and, partly, to bolster their own authority by appeals to religious symbols for a long time” (Mofidi, 2023). This can likewise be noted by many middle eastern countries, in which the usage of Islamic laws, or Sharia, are used to discriminate among women and same sex couples, specifically. To perpetuate the consequences religion imposes, wars have historically been tied to religion. Mofidi supports this claim, “During World War I, the soldiers of many nations, professing a religion of which the chief tenet is brotherly love, slaughtered each other in the name of God” (Mofidi, 2023). Religion, meant to civilize a

society, is not the root justification for war and violence. As shown previously by the Greeks, religion inclines to blind rational thinking. One of most significant and devastating wars in history had themes of religion which were used as propaganda. However, it is still ongoing in modern day among Israel and Palestine, despite not being a primarily religious conflict rather than a political one, similar to World War I. Israel justifies its claim to the land based on Biblical promise, seeing the land as divinely granted to the Jewish people, and many Palestinians claim their holy sites in Israel, particularly in Al-Aqsa Mosque in Jerusalem, one of the holiest places in Islam. Religion serves as a tool to mobilize people, but it also reinforces violence, making peace harder to achieve, being a precise example of Huntington's theory, indicating that cultural and religious differences will always become the main drivers of conflict above political disagreements (Kirkby, 2011).

Agriculture is the birth of civilization and the death of equality, the division that led to issues such as slavery, unequal gender roles, and hierarchy, harming the masses as it cements into society. While it was agriculture that laid the blueprint for division, it was religion that exacerbated it to a further extent. It is a tool for excuses, justifications, and violence. It has willingly convinced individuals to accept injustice and unequal treatment due to an unseen divine source that is meant to guide them; to let a man-made unknown source that is claimed to provide peace and reward those who worship it control how society functions and how nations operate is a surrender to rational thinking and an abdication of reason. Religion has been the root of false hope and a way for society to cope with the unknown, as many early civilizations once did. In the name of faith, wars have been caused, deaths have occurred, discrimination has made its mark, and the government has been corrupted. Religion became the birth of answers and the death of questioning, leaving an irreversible mark on human history, making it one of the greatest mistakes ever made.

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